

PANDA DIPLOMACY

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For centuries, giant pandas have held special significance in Chinese society. Legends, myths, and art throughout Chinese history often featured the panda. The first documented appearance of the animal can be traced back over 4,000 years to an ancient text. Historical records recount a conflict between two tribes that inhabited the Henan province. One of the tribes used native animals, including pandas, in their battle plans. In China, the panda, particularly its pelt and bones, represented status and wealth. Empress Dowager Bo was buried with a skull, and Emperor Tang Taizong reportedly gifted the animals to his honored guests after a banquet at his imperial palace. Despite the popularity and significance of pandas in China, they were not known to the Western world until 1869. French missionary and naturalist Père Armand David made the first documented sighting by a Westerner in 1896, marking the pandas' introduction to the world stage. A series of Western hunting explorations followed the first spotting. In 1929, Theodore Roosevelt Jr. and Kermit Roosevelt traveled to China in search of pandas. Ruth Harkness, an American fashion designer, captured a panda named Su-Lin in China and brought her back to the United States in 1936. Harkness faced difficulties exporting Su-Lin, so she reportedly listed Su-Lin as a dog in customs to successfully bring her to New York. Su-Lin briefly lived in Harkness's New York City apartment before becoming a major attraction at the Brookfield Zoo in Chicago. She died of pneumonia in April 1938. China used pandas for diplomatic efforts as early as 1941. Chiang Kai-Shek sent two pandas to the United States to thank them for helping Chinese refugees during the war with Japan. Panda diplomacy, however, was not fully utilized until after the fall of the Nationalist government in 1949. Since its

founding in 1949, the People's Republic of China has deployed giant pandas as a show of good faith to international allies and adversaries. In 1957, Chinese Communist Party leader Mao Zedong sent his first "panda ambassadors," Ping Ping and Qi Qi, to the Soviet Union to commemorate the 40th anniversary of the October Revolution. Mao gifted the United States two pandas in recognition of President Richard Nixon's visit to China in 1972. In exchange, Nixon sent two oxen to China. Between 1957 and 1983, twenty-four pandas were gifted to nine different nations. In 1984, Deng Xiaoping changed the policy from panda gifting to panda leasing to maintain control and ownership over the majority of the pandas in the world. All zoos were required to pay China per panda per year and had to maintain the health of the animals. In 1991, China began leasing pandas on a ten-year basis. Historical evidence suggests that China continues to use panda diplomacy because it helps the country boost its international image. Additionally, panda diplomacy promotes wildlife conservation and provides economic benefits for all parties involved. Furthermore, the darker side of panda diplomacy threatens to undermine United States-China relations.

China has long used panda diplomacy as a tool of soft power to enhance its international image. This strategy uses the symbolic value of pandas to strengthen diplomatic ties. China is able to foster goodwill and strengthen bonds with other nations by lending their beloved animals to zoos across the globe. Soft power, as defined by Joseph Nye, is the ability of one country to influence other global nations through persuasion and cultural appeal rather than through force and coercion. Soft power relies on cultural appeal that is considered legitimate and attractive to others across the globe. It aims to encourage a favorable international environment where other nations are more inclined to cooperate and align their interests. American University's School of International Service professor Judith Shapiro states that "the giant panda has been called into service in part because China needs to appear more approachable, softer, and unthreatening." China's political system, and especially its foreign policies, are often viewed as harsh and authoritarian. Pandas helped soften the image of China as more people began to associate them with the lovable pandas. Shapiro continues, saying, "A convergence of factors, including sheer cuteness... and the affections of humans from around the world, have helped to save the animal from extinction and provided China with a powerful diplomatic bargaining chip." The pandas' charm and widespread attraction have created an opportunity for China's diplomatic engagement. China is able to pave the way for deeper diplomatic ties with nations it would have otherwise not had the opportunity to do so by sharing its beloved national animal

with the world. The image of cuddly pandas has been seen on every corner of the globe. For example, as historian and author E. Elena Songster writes in her book *Panda Nation*, "outside of China, the giant panda is a logo for a fast food chain, a software program, a licorice company, and a non-profit environmental organization, among others." Moreover, pandas have become more than just animals on the global stage. They are cartoon characters and symbols of happiness and harmony. Its use in various different medians has demonstrated not only the pandas' broad global appeal but also its commercial value. The panda is a global icon and has marketability, with its value exploited for gain both within China as well as outside. The 2008 Olympic mascot serves as a definitive example of China utilizing the panda to project a positive national image. Ultimately, pandas have become a powerful symbol for China to use, representing the country's cultural heritage and growing influence on the global stage. Xie Feng, the Ambassador of China to the United States, echoes this sentiment, saying in a 2024 interview, "in pandas, we see the Chinese values of harmony, openness, inclusiveness, and shared prosperity. They reflect our two peoples' aspiration for friendship and exchanges, and also the world's longing for peace and cooperation. I encourage our American friends to care for China-U.S. relations just as you care for pandas, cherish the friendship between our two peoples just as you cherish pandas, and protect world peace just as you protect pandas." Moreover, the Chinese government has attempted to use pandas to protect against tensions with other countries. Xie said that pandas reflect Chinese values and paint China as a peaceful nation that wants to see the world move forward in a positive manner. US and China relations rely heavily on the use of pandas in American zoos. If Americans associate China with the soft and cuddly panda, they will be more likely to encourage their government officials to work with the Chinese government. The People's Republic of China's President Xi Jinping is eager to utilize pandas in the diplomatic process. In a 2023 speech, he said, "We are ready to continue our cooperation with the United States on panda conservation and do our best to meet the wishes of the Californians so as to deepen the friendly ties between our two peoples." Xi's emphasis on the Chinese's willingness to meet the needs and wants of the Californians demonstrates China's commitment to fostering positive relationships with recipient countries of pandas. Xi's mentioning that China hoped to deepen friendly ties demonstrates the broader objective of panda diplomacy—to foster closer relationships between nations. In summary, panda diplomacy is a multifaceted strategy that leverages the power of the charismatic panda to enhance China's global image and foster close relationships with panda recipient countries.

Panda diplomacy also plays a significant role in driving improvements in panda wildlife conservation within China. In 1990, pandas were officially declared endangered due to poaching and a decline in habitat. The beginnings of panda conservation, however, started even before the species was officially marked endangered. In 1976, the World Wildlife Fund signed an agreement with China to cooperate on conservation, specifically involving helping save the giant panda habitat. The World Wildlife Fund writes on their website that they were “the first international conservation organization to work in China at the Chinese government’s invitation.” The relationship where international organizations partner on domestic conservation shows the benefit of panda diplomacy. The collaboration between China and international nongovernmental organizations has fostered a better understanding of the best principles in wildlife conservation in China and has helped rescue the panda from endangerment. NGOs, particularly ones based in the United States, have also supported panda conservation. Ambassador Feng said in a 2024 interview that “the San Diego Zoo is the first U.S institution to carry out cooperation on panda conservation with China. When the first panda pair, Bai Yun and Shi Shi, arrived in 1996, that day was said to be the Super Bowl, World Series, and Academy Awards rolled into one. During our 28 years of cooperation, we have jointly developed a panda milk formula and helped increase the survival rates for panda cubs from around 10% to over 90%.” Collaboration between the zoo and China demonstrates the essential role of international partnerships in panda wildlife conservation. The San Diego Zoo has been a major contributor to panda wildlife conservation since the beginning of its exchange. According to the zoo’s website, “Dr. Ya-ping Zhang undertook the first population genetic studies of giant pandas in our Conservation Genetics lab. This groundbreaking study led to a complete analysis of the giant panda studbook population and identification of paternity for many cubs.” Scientists are now able to identify potential threats to the diversity of genes in pandas by analyzing the genetic data collected by the zoo. The study’s contribution to panda conservation is critical because it can help identify stable breeding pairs that can produce panda offspring with high genetic diversity, which will help the population thrive. The findings of the zoo’s study have the ability to improve the effectiveness of captive breeding programs. It also demonstrates the power of conservation genetics as a tool for helping endangered species. Ecologist Liu Jiansu of Michigan State University elaborated on the importance of a partnership between the United States and China on panda conservation, saying that the collaboration “introduced advanced technologies into China’s conservation efforts... Images from US satellites, for example, showed how forests and habitats changed over time on a

large scale.” The transfer of knowledge between two of the world’s biggest superpowers is a positive development, not only for the preservation of pandas but also for diplomatic relations between the two countries. Pandas benefit greatly from the two most technologically advanced countries in the world fighting for their survival. By providing US satellite imagery, scientists from both countries are able to collaborate to monitor habitat loss and track habitat connectivity. Technology plays a crucial role in modern wildlife conservation. Scientists are able to understand the threats facing pandas and develop different and more effective conservation strategies.

16 Additionally, panda diplomacy provides economic benefits to all parties involved in the exchange. The combination of pandas’ cuddly faces and playful expressions captivates large audiences and makes them an immensely popular attraction to see in person. During the panda’s first year in the United States (1972), according to the Richard Nixon Foundation, “an estimated 1.1 million people came to visit the pandas...and they have remained [a] top attraction for nearly 50 years.” The arrival of pandas at a zoo has a positive impact on the zoo’s economic performance. Pandas lead to a significant surge in attendance, translating to increased revenue from ticket sales. Beyond a rise in admissions, the increased number of visitors leads to greater concession sales and sales of other merchandise. Furthermore, the popularity of pandas as a zoo’s top attraction for 50 years demonstrates their sustained economic impact. The consistent stream of visitors contributes significantly to the zoo’s long-term financial stability. Additionally, the presence of pandas enhances the zoo’s reputation, attracting visitors not only to see the pandas but also to experience the zoo’s other attractions, creating a loyal visitor base that continuously supports the zoo. Zoos are able to capitalize on the public’s fascination with pandas by offering unique and exclusive experiences related to the pandas. For example, at the San Diego Zoo, visitors can book a 60-minute early morning walk with the pandas for \$92 a person. The premium experience demonstrates how zoos can leverage pandas to generate additional revenue. Even zoos outside the United States have experienced elevated incomes once pandas arrive. The Edinburgh Zoo in Edinburgh, Scotland “reported a 200% increase in visitor numbers following the arrival of Tian Tian and Yuan Guang.” The 200% increase in visitors represents a surge in zoo popularity, demonstrating the powerful draw that pandas have on humans. An increase in attendance directly translates to significant economic advantages for the zoo. The zoo’s increased revenue is able to have a ripple effect on the local economy. Visitors may stay in nearby hotels or shop at local businesses, contributing to the overall economy of the region. Additionally, the added prestige that pandas bring to

zoos can lead to increased corporate sponsorships and other philanthropic donations. The economic impact of pandas extends beyond local zoos and local economies. China, the exclusive home to the giant panda, leverages their national treasure to generate economic growth. Currently, only China and Mexico own their pandas. Mexico was gifted its pandas in 1975 and has been able to keep them because of reproduction. Furthermore, as the only owner of an abundance of pandas, China is able to control where they go and for how much money, and is thus a primary benefactor of the revenue they generate. When China loans its pandas, "...zoos have to pay an annual rental fee to China that could be \$1 million a year. Then, it costs an extra \$400,000 if any cubs are born and they must be returned-though not immediately." Pandas are, technically, the property of the Chinese government, as underscored by the fact that all panda cubs must be returned to China within a year of their birth. All of the parties involved in panda diplomacy are able to benefit greatly from its economic impact.

China continues to use panda diplomacy as a strategic tool in its foreign policies. By lending pandas to zoos and countries around the globe, China is able to enhance its global image and continue panda wildlife conservation efforts. Furthermore, China can generate economic benefits for all parties involved in panda diplomacy. Panda diplomacy, however, is not without its drawbacks. By trusting its beloved national treasure to the care of foreign nations and zoo programs, China demonstrates an extreme act of trust. When trust is breached, the consequences can be far-reaching and detrimental to China's relationship with certain countries. In particular, the delicate nature of panda diplomacy has the ability to be extremely damaging to US-Chinese relations, which are already in an increasingly delicate state. A perceived failure to provide only the best care for the panda ambassadors can quickly escalate to a diplomatic crisis. The most prominent example of this occurred at the Memphis Zoo in Tennessee in 2023. In February of 2023, the Memphis Zoo announced that one of its pandas, 25-year-old Le Le, had died, just months after it was announced that the panda would return to China in the coming spring. Critics alleged that Le Le and Ya Ya, his female companion, were living in sub-par conditions in the zoo. Concerns were raised about the quality of bamboo being included in their diet, suggesting a possible struggle with malnutrition for the pandas. The zoo denied the allegations, stating that Le Le was elderly when he died (the average lifespan of a panda is 20 years old) and had died of heart disease. The public was outraged by the death and alleged mistreatment. The controversy gained traction on social media, with many Chinese citizens demanding the early return of Ya Ya to China. Animal rights organizations and activists also demanded

Ya Ya's return, citing concerns about her welfare. Images began to circulate of Ya Ya, appearing thin and displaying signs of possible distress. Her fur was patchy and dull, lacking the vibrant colors seen in healthy pandas, and she was noticeably lethargic. The zoo alleged that Ya Ya suffered from a chronic skin and fur condition and was experiencing a flare-up. In April of 2023, Ya Ya was returned. Her homecoming was met with a wave of emotion within China. The alleged mistreatment soured the relationship between the United States zoos and China. Le Le and Ya Ya's case brought renewed attention to the ethical and moral questions of panda diplomacy and the welfare of pandas in captivity. Some argue that the use of pandas as a diplomatic tool exploits their status as national treasures and the priority of pandas should be for conservation efforts. Nonetheless, panda diplomacy positively affects China, and they likely will not be ending it anytime in the near future.

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